15. The Chinese Communist Party Rules ‘All Under Heaven’

Successive dynasties in China claimed to have the Mandate of Heaven, or divine sanction, to rule over the territory and people which lay within the limits of the empire at different periods in history. As we have seen in Chapter 13, it was under the Qing, which was the last dynasty to rule China, that the empire reached its maximum geographical extent. Each empire constituted the known Chinese world of the time, and this was ‘All Under Heaven’, reflecting the claim to centrality which has been a constant feature of the Chinese world view. As we shall see in this chapter, the CPC, which won the civil war in 1949 and established the PRC, implicitly slipped into the role of a succeeding dynasty, claiming to rule ‘All Under Heaven’ as inheritors of the vast empire won through conquest by the Qing.

But the CPC did not gain the Mandate of Heaven to rule immediately after the demise of the Qing dynasty in 1911, when China was thrown into a period of great tumult. Japanese military aggression from 1937 to 1945, when the Pacific War ended, led to loss of large chunks of territory and brought immense suffering to the Chinese people. Despite facing a common enemy in Japan, the KMT under Chiang Kai-shek and the communist forces was engaged in a brutal civil war, which compounded the misery of the people. The ‘century of humiliation’, described in Chapter 13, continued till 1949, when the CPC won the civil war. This chapter will chart the rise of the CPC from its birth in 1921 to the present and attempt to understand how it sees China’s place in the world. Does its behaviour draw from templates of the past? What departures have resulted from its ideological profession of Marxism and establishment of a Leninist state modelled on the Soviet Union? But before we do that, it is worth recalling briefly the events leading up to the communist victory in 1949.

At the end of the Second World War in 1945, Japan was defeated and the